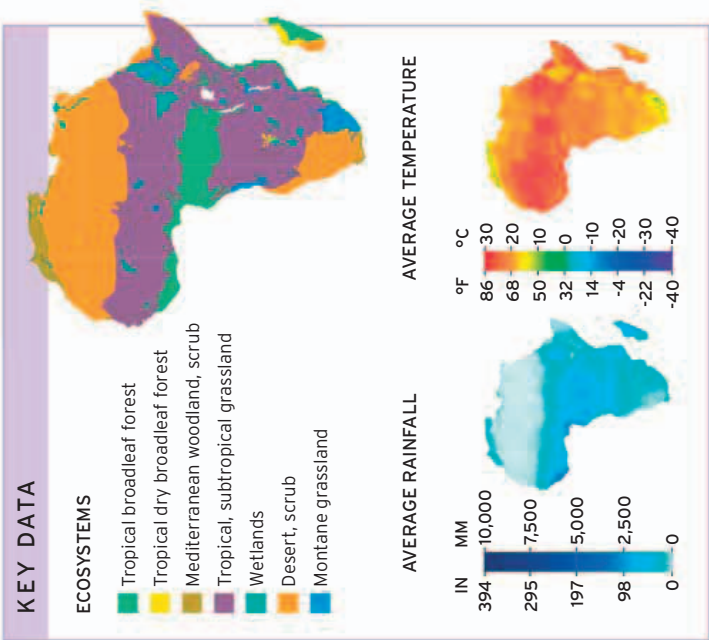


A SUNBAKED LAND

Africa

The second-largest continent, Africa covers 12 million sq miles (30 million sq km), and accounts for more than 20 percent of the world's land area. Dominated by sunbaked landscapes and tropical forest, Africa is famous for its wildlife. Even the rift valley lakes boast a spectacular diversity of cichlid fish that is every bit as impressive to zoologists as the large mammals of the Serengeti savannas are to tourists. Africa's habitats are some of the planet's most productive and biodiverse and include wetlands, uplands, and several major deserts as well as the forests and grasslands.

The eastern mountain ranges are part of the East African Rift, where the African plate is slowly splitting into two parts called the Somali and Nubian plates. The Great Rift Valley is one of its main arms. The Drakensberg range in South Africa marks the edge of a plateau that covers most of the south and east. The continent is drained by several great rivers, including the Nile, Niger, Congo, Zambezi, Limpopo, and Orange. Some rivers never reach the sea. The Okavango feeds a vast inland wetland, while the Chari drains into Lake Chad in the Sahel from which the water evaporates or seeps into the ground.



ATLAS MOUNTAINS

The Atlas Mountains formed in a region where the African plate is colliding with the Eurasian plate to the north. The highest point is Mount Toubkal in Morocco.

NILE DELTA

The vast Nile Delta fans out along 150 miles (240 km) of Egypt's Mediterranean coast. Its deep alluvial soils have been farmed for thousands of years.

SAHARA DESERT

The world's largest desert began to form 7 million years ago and is still growing. It covers about 30 percent of Africa's land area, limiting the north-south distribution of many species. Animals specially adapted to the dry conditions include the jerboa and fennec fox.

